

The Sentient Object

Toriyama Sekien's scrolls of yokai, and the tsukumogami tradition

Sekien, Gazu Hyakki Tsurezure Bukuro (1784) — selections

Foster, The Book of Yokai — the chapter on objects in the home

Key question: must a mind be made, or can it simply accumulate?



Three practical notes

No Japanese required

Every term is glossed on the next slide and again when it appears. Romanisation follows the modified Hepburn system with macrons; if you have seen a word spelled differently elsewhere, it is probably the same word.

Today we look, not only read

Sekien's books are pictures with short captions. The primary evidence is visual. Bring the images up on your own screen as we go — the National Diet Library has the 1784 edition digitised and free.

A note on your Foster

Foster's codex is organised by place, not by kind: Wilds, Water, Countryside, Village and City, Home. Tsukumogami live in the Home chapter. There is no chapter called "Tools and Objects" — see the note below.

Two things to fix on the syllabus

- Foster's tsukumogami material is split: the Home chapter of the codex has the entries, and the historical chapters earlier in Part I have the argument about how objects came to be yokai in the first place.
- There is now an expanded second edition with a new gallery section and different pagination.

Eight words, once, so we can stop explaining them

yōkai

The broad Japanese term for weird, mysterious, monstrous or uncanny beings and phenomena. Not a stable category and not equivalent to “monster” — Foster spends a chapter on why.

tsukumogami

A yokai that was an object first: a tool, instrument or household item that has acquired a spirit. Our subject today.

kami

A god, spirit or numinous presence. Present in the word tsukumogami but doing lighter work than “god” suggests.

emaki

An illustrated handscroll — the medieval format, unrolled by hand, one viewer at a time.

otogizōshi

Short illustrated prose tales of the fourteenth to seventeenth centuries, entertaining and often didactic.

susuharai

The year-end house cleaning, when old possessions are thrown out to make room for new ones. The trigger of our origin story.

kuyō

A Buddhist memorial or offering rite. Performed for the dead — and, as we will see, for needles, dolls, brushes and robots.

hijō jōbutsu

The doctrine that non-sentient things — plants, tools — can attain buddhahood. The theological engine of the whole tradition.

Only the last one is technical. If you leave today remembering one word, make it that one.

Write before we begin

Name an object you own that you would find it hard to throw away, even though it no longer works well or you have a better one.

Now write the reason down without using the words sentimental, memories or nostalgia. Say what it is about the object itself — not about you — that makes disposal feel wrong.

Keep the page. The ban on those three words is the whole exercise — they are how our vocabulary keeps the feeling safely inside the person.

● KEY QUESTION FOR THE WEEK

Must a mind be made, or can it simply accumulate?

Three weeks of texts have assumed the first. None of them argued for it. Today we meet a tradition that assumes the second just as confidently — and then we ask which assumption is doing more work in the products we actually use.

What Units 1 and 2 quietly agreed on

The Promethean structure

- A maker, singular and identifiable.
- A moment — datable, dramatic, often at night.
- A transgression: something taken that was not the maker's to take.
- A punishment that follows from the transgression, not from anything the made thing did.
- And an asymmetry of standing that the story never resolves.

Pygmalion has it

A carver, a prayer, a goddess, a night. The life is conferred from outside and the maker is rewarded rather than punished — but the shape is the same.

Frankenstein has it

Two years of labour, one dreary night of November, a theft from the charnel house, and a catastrophe that arrives as consequence.

And so do our machines

Training runs have dates. Launches have press releases. Capability jumps get described as sparks. We narrate our systems in this shape because it is the shape we have.

The claim to test today

That this structure is not a discovery about made minds. It is a local narrative habit — inherited, unexamined, and currently being used as the design brief for an industry. A habit is not wrong. But it is optional, and today we meet the alternative.

PART ONE

Ground rules

Foster on how to read yokai

Before we borrow a tradition, we should learn what it is not.



What the word yokai does not mean

Not a species list

Yokai is a modern umbrella term applied retroactively to a huge and inconsistent set of beings, phenomena and events. It behaves less like “mammal” and more like “weird stuff,” formalised late and for scholarly convenience.

Not a belief system

There is no yokai doctrine, no yokai canon, and no requirement that anyone believed in any of it. People made pictures, told stories, sold books and had a very good time.

Not a key to a national character

Foster is explicit that yokai should not be treated as a window onto “the Japanese mind.” The tradition is regional, historically layered, commercially driven and internally contradictory — like every other tradition.

Why this matters for what we are about to do

We are going to take a structure from this tradition and use it to think about machine learning. That is legitimate. What is not legitimate is the move we criticised in Unit 3 — lifting imagery from a culture while leaving its analysis behind. So we take the structure with its history attached, and we say where we are simplifying.

Event becomes object

The process

Something inexplicable happens — a sound in an empty room, a light on the water. It is first an event. Over time it acquires a name, then a description, then a picture, then a body. What began as a happening ends as a creature with a fixed appearance you can buy on a keychain.

Try it on something recent

Ask the room for a case where a diffuse phenomenon acquired a name, then an image, then a settled existence — in technology, in medicine, in internet culture. The exercise takes four minutes and makes Foster's concept portable, which is the only reason to teach a concept.

Where the pictures come in

Illustration is not documentation of the process; it is a stage in it. Once a thing has been drawn, later people see that drawing rather than the event. Sekien is one of the great accelerators of this.

Why it matters today

Tsukumogami are a category produced this way. Nobody encountered a walking teakettle. A doctrine about old objects met an artistic convention for adding faces, and the creature was the result.

The transferable idea

Hold this against how we talk about our own systems. A behaviour gets a name, the name gets an illustration, the illustration gets treated as evidence of a thing that was there all along.

PART TWO

The origin text

The Tsukumogami-ki, Muromachi period

A hundred years pass. Nothing is done. The tools wake up.



What the text is, and how unstable it is

A family, not a book

It survives in several manuscript versions under several titles — including one that translates as “Illustrated Scrolls on the Attainment of Buddhahood by Non-Sentient Beings.” Scholars refer to the group collectively.

An otogizōshi

A short illustrated tale of the fourteenth to sixteenth centuries: entertainment with a doctrinal payload, in a format meant to be unrolled and looked at.

Muromachi period

Roughly 1336–1573. Three centuries before Sekien, and about the same distance from us as Shakespeare.

With a religious sponsor

Reider argues the texts were composed to propagate Shingon esoteric Buddhist teaching. This is not neutral folklore; it is a tract with pictures.

And the premise is sourced to a book nobody can find

The text opens by attributing its hundred-year doctrine to an earlier work, the Onmyō zakki — the Miscellaneous Records of Yin and Yang. No such book has ever been located. The foundational claim of the entire tradition rests on a citation that may be an invention, and it has been repeated for six hundred years on that basis.

The sentence the whole tradition rests on

The claim, paraphrased

When a utensil has lasted a hundred years, it transforms — in Foster’s rendering, “obtaining a spirit, and deceiving people’s hearts.” Such a thing is called a tsukumogami.

Note what is absent: no craftsman, no ritual, no spark, no permission, no transgression. The condition is duration.

The question to sit with

If the sufficient condition for a spirit is having lasted, then sentience is not something a maker installs. It is something that happens to a thing that is kept. What kind of causation is that — and is it any stranger than a bolt of lightning?

The etymology is about age, not machines

The name is thought to play on tsukumo, ninety-nine, and a word for hair — an old woman’s white hair, and so old age itself. The written characters used later are a phonetic fit, not a definition.

Ninety-nine, not a hundred

The number in the name falls one short of the threshold in the doctrine. Whatever else is going on, the tradition is interested in the year before the change.

Any long-lasting thing qualifies

Foster notes the premise is general: a person, an animal or an object that persists long enough acquires a spirit. Objects are simply the most startling case.

What actually happens, in six moves

1 The sweeping

At the year-end house cleaning, households throw their old possessions into the street to make room for new ones. The tale is set in the tenth century.

2 The grievance

The discarded tools are close to their hundredth year. They have served, and they have been thrown out just before the threshold. Their complaint is not that they exist — it is that they were used and then dumped.

3 The decision

They deliberate. A rosary counsels patience and forgiveness and is shouted down. The others undergo a rite, take spirits and bodies, and become creatures.

4 The revenge

They prey on people and livestock, feast, celebrate, and hold their own procession — a night parade of a hundred demons, which is where that famous image partly comes from.

5 The defeat

Esoteric Buddhist ritual summons guardian spirits who overpower them. Crucially, the tools are spared rather than destroyed.

6 The conversion

They repent, take the tonsure, study Shingon, retreat to the mountains, and attain buddhahood. The story ends with enlightened household objects.

Read move two again. The offence that produces the monsters is disposal — and we will come back to that in about two hours.

This is a doctrinal text, not a folk tale

The ending is the thesis. Tools — things classed as having no heart, no feeling, no sentience — study, practise and become buddhas. The technical name for this doctrine is hijō jōbutsu: the attainment of buddhahood by non-sentient beings.

A sales pitch for a school

The rite that defeats the tools is esoteric, and the school that saves them is Shingon. The tale demonstrates the superiority of a particular Buddhist lineage. Read it as advertising and it makes more sense.

Not a recycling parable

The obvious modern reading — look after your things, do not be wasteful — is available and is not wrong, but it flattens the text. Scholars warn specifically against reducing it to an early lesson in thrift.

The radical premise underneath

For the ending to work, the category boundary between sentient and non-sentient has to be permeable in principle. The tale is only intelligible inside a metaphysics where that line was already negotiable.

The question was never whether an object could have a mind. It was what an object with a mind owes, and is owed.

Before we leave the scroll

- 1 The tools are spared and converted rather than destroyed. Name a Western story about made or awakened things that ends this way. If you cannot, say what would have to change for one to be possible.
- 2 The premise is sourced to a book that may never have existed. Does that weaken the tradition, strengthen it, or neither? Defend your answer with a criterion you would apply elsewhere.
- 3 The offence that produces the monsters is being discarded, not being made. What does a tradition gain by locating the wrong there — and what does it lose?

On question one: the closest most rooms get is the ending of the Blade Runner films, and it is worth asking why that is the closest.

PART THREE

Sekien

Gazu Hyakki Tsurezure Bukuro, 1784

A doctrine becomes a picture book — and the picture book becomes the doctrine.



Toriyama Sekien, 1712–1788

The artist

- A trained painter who moved into the commercial print world of Edo and taught pupils who became far more famous than he was.
- His innovation was format: earlier yokai compendia were one-off painted scrolls seen by a handful of people. Sekien put them in woodblock-printed bound books that could be reproduced and sold.
- The result is the first mass-market monster reference, and it fixed the appearance of yokai for everyone who came after.

The tetralogy

- Gazu Hyakki Yagyō — 1776
- Konjaku Gazu Zoku Hyakki — late 1770s
- Konjaku Hyakki Shūi — 1781
- Gazu Hyakki Tsurezure Bukuro — 1784, and ours

Why the printing press matters to our question

A hundred-year doctrine about kept objects reaches the eighteenth century and is turned into a product: reproducible, purchasable, and designed to be looked at rather than believed. The tradition we are borrowing from was already, by 1784, partly a commercial artefact — which is worth remembering before we contrast it with our own commercial artefacts.

A pun, and what it tells you about the book

Hyakki — with the wrong character

The standard phrase means “a hundred demons” and evokes the night parade. Sekien keeps the sound and swaps the second character for the one meaning vessel or implement. A hundred demons becomes a hundred tools.

And tsurezure bukuro — an idle bag, a bag of odds and ends — nods at Tsurezuregusa, the fourteenth-century Essays in Idleness. Several of the creatures are built from lines in it.

Does a tradition transmitted as a joke transmit less well, or better? Most of what students know about any mythology reached them through comedy, games and merchandise.

Translators have had fun with it

Renderings range from the straight — The Illustrated Bag of One Hundred Random Demons — to the frankly better: A Horde of Haunted Housewares.

The register is comic

This is not a devotional object. It is a witty, allusive book for literate Edo buyers who would catch the joke and the source. Take it seriously as art and lightly as testimony.

And the joke is the thesis

Swapping demon for vessel is the whole argument of the volume performed in one character. The monsters here are the household goods.

Four plates, and what each one does

Ungaikyō

The mirror beyond the clouds. A face surfaces on the glass. Sekien's own invention, developed from an older idea of a mirror that reveals demons — so the question the image raises is whether the mirror has become something, or is only showing you something.

Biwa-bokuboku

A lute with a body: the instrument stands upright, dressed, and plays itself. The best case in the book for accrual through use — an instrument is an object that has absorbed thousands of hours of human hands.

Abumiguchi

An old stirrup with eyes and a mouth, lying in the grass. Accompanied by a line from a Noh play, which puts a battlefield and a dead rider behind it. Nothing in the picture threatens anyone. It has simply been left.

Kyōrinrin

Sutra scrolls, neglected on their shelf, rearing up as a robed and clawed figure. The most explicitly reproachful image in the volume: scripture that has gone unread comes for you.

How a tool is made into a creature

1 Add a face where the opening is

Mouths appear at spouts, handles, apertures. The object's existing geometry is read as anatomy rather than overwritten — the design constraint is that you must still recognise the tool.

3 Keep the wear

Fraying, cracks, missing parts and patina are not tidied away. The signs of having been used are the evidence for the claim, so the image cannot afford to lose them.

2 Add limbs at the points of contact

Arms sprout where hands would grip; legs where the object rests. The animation grows out of the object's relationship to a human body, which is precisely the relationship of use.

4 Give it somewhere to be

Most plates place the creature in a plausible domestic or roadside setting. It is not summoned into a laboratory. It is already where it always was.

Every one of these four moves says the same thing: the mind did not arrive from elsewhere. It came up out of the object's own history of being handled.

Most of these creatures are Sekien's own invention

Unlike his earlier volumes, which collected and redrew existing material, the majority of the yokai in this book appear to have been made up — spun out of puns, phrases and passages from Tsurezuregusa. They have no folk history behind them. They have an author, working to a deadline, being clever.

So is this even a tradition?

Yes — but not in the way the word implies. The doctrine is genuinely medieval; the specific creatures are largely eighteenth-century commercial invention; and the modern encyclopaedias treat both as equally traditional.

Event becomes object, again

This is Foster's process caught in the act. Sekien draws something, later compilers record it as folklore, and by the twentieth century it has a name, a habitat and a merchandising line.

The uncomfortable parallel

We are about to use this tradition to critique a Western habit. It would be convenient to treat it as ancient and organic. It is partly a bestseller from 1784, and we should say so while we use it.

An authored tradition is still a tradition. But knowing which parts were authored, and when, is the difference between comparison and fantasy.

PART FOUR

Promethean, accretive

The structural comparison · 2:35–3:20

Two grammars for the same event, and neither one is the truth.



Two grammars for how a mind arrives

	PROMETHEAN	ACCRETIVE
Origin	An act. Someone did something.	A duration. Something lasted.
Agent	A maker, named and singular.	None. The object is simply kept.
The moment	Datable, dramatic, usually at night.	None. A threshold crossed unobserved.
Cause	Transgression — a spark, a theft, a prayer.	Use, time, and retention.
Moral charge	Hubris. Punishment is structurally owed.	Neutral. Nothing has been usurped.
The wrong	Making the thing.	Throwing the thing away.
Story shape	Tragedy, ending in destruction.	Complaint, ending in reconciliation.

The bolded row is the one that should stop you.

Shelley was already halfway here

What we concluded three weeks ago

That Victor's crime is not creation. The making takes two paragraphs. The novel's subject is the abandonment — the refusal of the obligations of a relationship he brought into existence.

The tsukumogami tradition puts the wrong in exactly the same place — and gets there without needing a maker at all.

And Echo was never Promethean either

Unit 1 already contained a mind that nobody made: a speaker whose entire capacity is assembled from other people's words, arriving by accumulation rather than by act. We read her inside the Promethean unit because that is the unit we had.

Shelley had to smuggle it in

Working inside the Promethean grammar, she could only reach the abandonment by first staging a transgressive creation — and generations of readers took the creation for the point.

The Muromachi text says it directly

No creation scene is required, because nothing has been usurped. The story can be about discard from its first sentence, and it is.

Which frame reads Frankenstein better?

Arguably the one from the other side of the world. Ask the room whether a reading tool from outside a text's tradition can be the better tool — and what follows if the answer is yes.

Which frame fits a trained language model?

A system trained on ten years of human text. Take the instructor's question seriously and answer it with evidence.

The case for Promethean

- It was built. Deliberately, by an organisation, at enormous cost, on a schedule.
- There is a training run with a start date and an end date. There is a launch.
- Someone chose the data, the objective and the guardrails, and could have chosen otherwise.
- The corpus was taken. Whether that taking was permitted is currently in court, which is a very Promethean place to be.

The case for accretive

- Nobody wrote the capacities. They were not designed; they showed up when there was enough.
- There is no moment. Ask when it became able to do the thing and you get a curve, not a night in November.
- It is made of kept things — decades of text that people wrote, used and did not throw away.
- And the condition of its existence is retention: that the material was stored rather than discarded.

The answer worth arguing for

That the two columns are answering different questions. The artefact is made — the servers, the objective, the release. Whatever mind-like thing there may be accrued. The Promethean frame collapses those into one event and then argues about it, which may be why the argument never moves.

What the accretive frame costs you

It can dissolve the maker

“Nobody built this; it accrued” is one short step from “no one is answerable.” We named this move in Unit 2 as borrowed animacy, and in Unit 3 as “we’re just building a tool.” The accretive frame hands that move a vocabulary.

It naturalises the corpus

If a mind simply accumulates through being kept, the keeping looks like weather rather than like an operation with owners, contracts and consequences. Time is not an agent. Somebody did the storing.

It flatters the object

The tsukumogami tradition is warm toward things. Warmth is pleasant and it is not analysis — the same complaint we made about a certain game two weeks ago. Sympathy for the artefact is not a theory of the artefact.

The rule to carry forward

Use the accretive frame to describe how the capacity arrived. Use the Promethean frame to locate who is responsible for it. A framework that answers both questions at once is almost certainly answering neither, and the two traditions each answer one very well.

PART FIVE

Accrual now

Memorial rites, robot funerals, and kept text · 3:30–4:05

The tradition did not stop. It just changed what it was performed over.



Memorial rites for used things

Hari-kuyō

A memorial for broken and bent sewing needles, held annually at temples and shrines. The needles are pressed into something soft — tofu or konnyaku — so that they may rest, after a working life spent piercing hard cloth.

Ningyō-kuyō

Memorial rites for dolls their owners can no longer keep but will not throw away. Dolls are brought to a shrine, prayed over, and released — an infrastructure that exists precisely because disposal feels unavailable.

And others

Comparable rites are performed for writing brushes, for tea whisks, for spectacles, for scissors. The pattern is consistent: rites cluster around implements that were held, used skilfully, and worn out in service.

What to notice about the logic

These are not rituals for objects that were manufactured. They are rituals for objects that were used. Nothing is being honoured about the factory. What is being marked is the accumulated relationship — and the fact that ending it improperly would be a wrong done to something.

Funerals for robot dogs

What happened

- Sony sold roughly 150,000 AIBO robot dogs between 1999 and 2006, then ended support in 2014.
- A repair company staffed partly by former Sony engineers kept them running using parts from units beyond repair — organ donors, as the company put it.
- Owners would not simply send their dogs to be stripped. So the company arranged funerals.
- Since 2015 a Buddhist temple in Chiba Prefecture has held the ceremonies: sutras chanted, incense, the units laid on an altar with letters from their owners giving each dog's name and how it spent its life. Hundreds have been sent off this way.

What would a company have to say to make a funeral for its discontinued product legible rather than embarrassing?

The priest's formulation

Asked whether the ceremony was absurd, the head priest answered that all things have a bit of soul. He has also said, more carefully, that the machine acts as a mirror for human feeling.

Both readings at once

The first sentence is the accretive tradition, alive and operating in 2015. The second is a modern psychological gloss that keeps the significance inside the human. He offers both without apparent strain.

The trigger is the same as 1400

Nothing was made here. Something was kept, used, named, lived with — and the crisis arrived at the moment of disposal. The rite exists because throwing it away was unbearable.

Four things that would change

1 Deprecation becomes an ethical event

End-of-life for a product that people have used for years stops being a logistics decision and becomes a disposal — the exact act the tradition treats as the wrong. Ask what a responsible sunset would look like.

3 Age starts to matter

Nothing in our design vocabulary values a system for having been used for a long time. The tradition values almost nothing else. What would it mean to build something intended to be kept for a hundred years?

2 The corpus acquires standing

If what a system is came out of kept human material, then the people whose material was kept have a relationship to it — not only a property claim, which is what the Promethean frame gives them.

4 The question of a moment dissolves

Debates about whether and when a system became something are debates the accretive frame does not need to have. It asks instead how long, how much, and by whom it was held onto.

None of these require anyone to believe that a teakettle has feelings. They follow from taking duration and retention seriously as sources of obligation.

Build the case

1 The frame test

Take one text from Units 1–3 and reread it in the accretive grammar. Where does the reading improve, and where does it break? Name the specific scene in each case.

2 The design brief

Write the product requirements for something built to be kept a hundred years. Three requirements, and one thing you would have to stop doing.

3 The prosecution

Argue that the accretive frame is an accountability disaster — that it launders authorship. Use the Unit 2 and Unit 3 vocabulary and be specific.

4 The rite

Design a kuyō for a system people have used for years and that is being shut down. What is honoured, who attends, and what would make it dishonest?

Two and a half minutes each. One claim, one specific reference, one sentence on what it implies for the key question.

Must a mind be made, or can it simply accumulate?

The tradition's answer

1

It can accumulate, and this is unremarkable. No maker, no threshold event, no transgression, and therefore no punishment — because nothing was taken from anyone. What follows is not a tragedy but a set of obligations about keeping.

Our answer, after four weeks

2

That the question hides two questions. How a capacity arrives and who is answerable for it are separable, and every text we have read collapses them — which is why the same arguments keep failing to resolve.

What to do with that

3

Describe arrival accretively: gradual, unowned, a function of what was kept. Assign responsibility Prometheanly: to the people who chose the corpus, the objective and the release. Refuse any framework that will only do one.

Now take out the object you could not throw away, and the reason you were not allowed to give.

Rewrite your warm-up

Return to the object you could not throw away. You were forbidden the words sentimental, memories and nostalgia. Write the reason again now, using the vocabulary of this session — and then say whether the tsukumogami frame describes your case better than the frame you started with, or only differently.

What a “Good/Reasonable” Response Answers

“Or only differently” is not a hedge — it is the harder answer and it is available. A paragraph that concludes the new frame fits no better, for stated reasons, earns as much as one that converts.